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India sent its biggest boxing contingent—five young men—to scale their sport's Great Wall: the Olympics. Three of them got to within eight minutes of that elusive first medal while one became his sport's barrier breaker.



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PACKING PUNCHES ►►►

Only twice Indian pugilists reached Olympics quarter-finals before Beijing 2008

NAME	OLYMPICS	WEIGHT	POSITION
R. Norris	Helsinki, 1952	69 kg	Fifth
Gurcharan Singh	Sydney, 2000	81 kg	Quarter-finalist
Akhil Kumar	Beijing, 2008	54 kg	Quarter-finalist
Jitender Kumar	Beijing, 2008	51 kg	Quarter-finalist
Vijender Kumar	Beijing, 2008	75 kg	Semi-finalist*

* At the time of going to the press

clenched fist. Of them, three got to within eight minutes of a medal and when all hope but perished with quarter-final defeats for two, the last man left standing was Vijender Kumar, a stylish, made-for-showbiz middleweight boxer who became his sport's barrier breaker.

It has been a privilege to watch them fight, entering the ring at Beijing's Worker's Gymnasium with heads high, waving to the crowd, blowing kisses before clambering into their workrooms.

Every night, two Indians have turned up faithfully trying to get the crowd to pick up their Mandarin chant, "*Indu, gia yoh* (India come on)". The boxers have left the ring equally proudly, victorious or defeated, tricolours draped around sweating shoulders, voices steady, words confident.

Until this week, the most enduring memory from India's Olympic boxing experience was a distraught Gurcharan Singh on his knees in Sydney, defeated on countback after

coming within 14 seconds of a semi-final spot. The memories from Beijing will be very different: the elegant Vijender, 22, dancing around the ring supremely sure of his destiny. Lippy bantamweight Akhil Kumar walking out of his lost quarter-final bout, with a very red sclera having caught a blow square on and saying, "If I can take a close victory, then I should have the heart to take defeat—after all, I'm a boxer, not just any kind of sportsman." Or Jitender Kumar, 20 and a quarter-finalist in only his first Olympics, saying, "*Hum kyon kisi se daren?*" (Why should we be afraid of anyone?)

These are India's undaunted. At ease on the biggest stage in their sport, from where names like Evander Holyfield have springboarded into pro careers. Olympic boxing is a curious fusion of blood lust and rigid rules: only direct, visible, full-impact punches count for points with the judges. Scores tend to be low, with every fighter trying to establish a lead and then let his opponent do the chasing. It happens all too quickly, a man's years of work and sweat, compressed into eleven minutes of jabbing, feinting, seeking the opening, snapping a punch and hoping it will register in judge's eyes. It is not for the weak of purpose.

Boxers are a brotherhood of the hungry and despite personal rivalries, share a sense of being brethren. In Beijing, one of the five had to be dragged away before he took a swing at an Indian official dumping non-stop on Akhil after his defeat. The surge by the boxers has caught India in the solar plexus. In 108 years, India had sent only two boxers into the last eight of the Olympics. In two weeks, three sons from the most modest homes, making do on four-figure salaries, gave themselves a shot at achieving something that only five other Indians have done. It sends the boxers' South African physiotherapist Heath Matthews into metaphoric overdrive, "The boxers are the bread and butter of India, the salt of the earth."

For the majority, bread and salted butter included, the barriers into shooting and golf, two individual sports